

UNGEKN Strategic Plan and Programme of Work 2021-2029

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FOREWORD

Message from the Chair

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Message from the Director

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Director UNSD

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The 'new' United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names (UNGEGN) was established by the United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) resolution 20/18/2 in November 2017, replacing both the United Nations five-yearly Conferences on the Standardization of Geographical Names and the former UNGEGN.

Recommendation 1 of the first session of the new UNGEGN held in New York, 29 April to 3 May 2019, adopted by ECOSOC as decision E/2019/230 (dated 23/7/2019), approved the development of a draft strategic plan and programme of work to be undertaken by the UNGEGN Bureau:

Recommendation 1

The Economic and Social Council:

- (a) *Decides that, in close consultation with States Members of the United Nations, the Bureau of the United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names should undertake the development of a draft strategic plan and programme of work for the new Group of Experts, which, inter alia, should take into account:*
 - i. *The mandate and structure of the Group;*
 - ii. *Support for the creation of new national geographical names authorities and strengthening the operation of existing ones;*
 - iii. *The establishment of funding mechanisms (such as a trust fund) to support the implementation of the strategic plan;*
 - iv. *Appropriate branding and publicity for the Group;*
 - v. *The focus and core goals of its parent body, the Economic and Social Council;*
 - vi. *A suitable planning timeframe;*
- (b) *Also decides that the draft strategic plan and programme of work shall be circulated to Member States for consideration prior to adoption at the second session of the United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names.*

Accordingly, the Bureau in cooperation with convenors of the current Working Groups, has prepared this draft Strategic Plan for the period 2021 to 2029, in consultation with Member States, which have been formally consulted three times. The first consultation was done at the start of the exercise in October 2019, which asked Member States to identify national geographical names standardization issues and priority actions. The second consultation in June 2020, invited Member States to review and provide comments on the first draft of the Strategic Plan. Based on the feedback received, the Bureau prepared a revised version of the draft Strategic Plan, which was combined with the first draft of the Programme of Work and circulated in February 2021 for the third round of consultations.

This document presents the vision, values and aims of UNGEGN, together with the following five strategies and their collective alignment to the relevant goals of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

1. Technical expertise
2. Relationships, links and connections
3. Effective work programmes
4. Culture, heritage and language recognition
5. Promotion and capacity building

For each strategy, the main achievements, current status and future needs are noted, followed by the presentation of the Programme of Work responsibilities, outputs and timeframes up to 2029.

Two sections of the document are devoted to financing and monitoring, reporting and evaluation. In addition, the document includes a SWOT (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats) analysis, a brief history of UNGEGN, the current organization chart, and implementation framework.

Presentation of the draft Strategic Plan for UNGEGN's acceptance will take place at the 2nd Session of UNGEGN scheduled for May 2021.

INTRODUCTION

Brief History of UNGEGN

ECOSOC resolution 715A (XXVII) of 1959 encouraged nations to have a national organization for the standardization of geographical names and to set up a group of experienced consultants from

interested governments. Since the first meeting of this group in 1960, 30 sessions have been held, with the name UNGEGN formalized in 1972. From 1967 to 2017, 11 five-yearly conferences were convened, providing forums to encourage national standardization, to promote international dissemination, and to endorse a single standardized and scientific romanization system for each non-Roman-script language.

For nearly 60 years, UNGEGN established a cooperative framework, followed up conference resolutions and promoted geographical names standardization, through its geographical/linguistic divisions and topical working groups, publications, website and training activities.

In 2017 the time was appropriate to review the conference and session structure and working methods with a view to operational efficiencies, cost-savings and improved decision making. As a result, the conferences and UNGEGN were discontinued and a new UNGEGN was established (ECOSOC 2018/2), to be convened every two years starting in 2019, with the existing mandates. UNGEGN now has full authority to set its strategic direction and adopt resolutions to be submitted to ECOSOC.

Outreach

As an expert body of ECOSOC, UNGEGN engages to strengthen communications with other UN bodies, providing advice on the use of standardized geographical names within their programmes; this in particular links to geospatial needs of UN-GGIM and the 2030 Agenda on Sustainable Development, as well as to the cultural heritage value of names relevant to a range of objectives and activities of the UN. As avoiding ambiguity in geographical names has economic and social benefits, and supports infrastructure development, UNGEGN also collaborates with non-UN international organizations, especially those with related scientific and technical interests. UNGEGN extends the promotion of its ideals and practices on standardization to the media and to the general public.

SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis of Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats was undertaken to consider internal and external factors affecting UNGEGN's current situation and its future operations. The following SWOT diagram was created by the UNGEGN Bureau and Secretariat. It assisted the Bureau to understand UNGEGN's position and provided a framework that helped to guide preparation of the Strategic Plan and Programme of Work.

UNEGN's Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats

VISION

Every country to have a fully functioning and globally-aligned structure and policy framework, based on common principles, standardization of authorized geographical names that identify location and respect the associated culture and heritage, names easily accessible for national and international use - facilitating consistent worldwide use of geographical names for communication and cooperation.

VALUES

Inclusive, Collaborative, Respectful, Relevant Influential:

- i. We will work inclusively and collaboratively, aiming at consensus-building and harmony;
- ii. We will protect and uphold the integrity of our outcomes, demonstrating respect, expertise, professionalism and transparency;
- iii. Our products and outcomes will be solution oriented, relevant, user-friendly, innovative, and fully and equitably accessible;
- iv. We will share our knowledge, offer education, plan for succession, promote good practices and make an impact in the right direction.

AIMS

- i. Raise awareness of the value and benefits of national and international geographical names standardization.
- ii. Facilitate the creation or improvement of national geographical names standardization principles, policies and procedures.
- iii. Recognize, respect and promote the value of geographical names as significant elements of cultural heritage and national identity, including those of indigenous peoples and regional and minority groups.
- iv. Enhance, nationally, regionally and globally, the maintenance and dissemination of standardized geographical names.
- v. Consider, contribute to and endorse a single standardized and scientific romanization system for each non-Latin language; systems are proposed by donor countries, and intended for international use. Recommend methods of transcription of names from non-written languages.
- vi. Provide an active forum for Member States to exchange information, discuss and learn of good practices on the standardization of geographical names, including their use in geospatial information systems.
- vii. Provide leadership in the implementation of resolutions and recommendations adopted at the former United Nations conferences on the Standardization of Geographical Names and at the sessions of the UNGEGN Group of Experts.
- viii. Be recognized as the main source of expertise on a global level on standardization of geographical names.
- ix. Contribute geographical names expertise and advice to the work of other United Nations bodies, including the 2030 Agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals, taking note of their suggestions.
- x. Collaborate with relevant non-United Nations organizations.
- xi. Involve relevant stakeholders to contribute to the standardization of geographical names and to promote their use.

STRATEGIES

Strategy 1: Technical Expertise

- i. Deliver technical expertise and advice to interested parties in Member States for geographical names standardization, romanization and quality geographical names data and gazetteer management as well as interoperability;
- ii. Develop, extend and share good data management practices of Member States; and
- iii. Identify trends on developments and future direction for geographical names data management and encourage innovative methods, integrated approaches and technological advances to further the aims of UNGEGN.

Strategy 2: Relationships, links and connections

- i. Strengthen UNGEGN's existing collaboration vis-à-vis other United Nations activities (including the 2030 Agenda, development, and programmes of UNNECA, UNESCO, UN-GGIM and UNPFII);
- ii. Collaborate with non-United Nations scientific and academic bodies to provide expertise on geographical names and create synergy to promote the work of UNGEGN and United Nations Member States; and
- iii. Create new strategic partnerships with different stakeholders (both UN and non-UN bodies) to address the needs and challenges emerge.

Strategy 3: Effective work programmes

- i. Encourage active participation and promote compatible standards and methods in the work undertaken to contribute to UNGEGN's aims;
- ii. Deliver products, outcomes, policy guidance and advice that support coordinated activities at national, regional and international levels, taking note of UNGEGN resolutions and recommendations and leveraging social media, mobile and web-based tools;
- iii. Ensure that UNGEGN's organizational structure is appropriate, efficient, relevant and impactful to deliver results to Member States; and
- iv. Encourage exchange of knowledge, good practices and experience among Member States, aided by Divisional Groups, to facilitate development of legislation and policies on geographical names standardization at the national level.

Strategy 4: Culture, heritage and language recognition

- i. Declare, promote, celebrate and demonstrate that geographical names matter because they recognize unique cultures and language that connect people to physical locations;
- ii. Promote good geographical naming practices that acknowledge people's place in the world;
- iii. Recognize that geographical names are a source of identity, encourage recognition of heritage and equality, and support the role of names in the development of national, regional and/or minority groups' language revitalization and preservation; and
- iv. Contribute to building technical capabilities, such as developing guidelines, legislation, communication tools and training, to enhance culture, heritage and language recognition.

Strategy 5: Promotion and capacity building

- i. Raise awareness of the importance of using standardized geographical names and their role as a crucial element in the development of information;
- ii. Enhance the visibility of UNGEGN through its publications, improved communications, outreach, networking and partnerships;
- iii. Assist Member States in their capacity building and in the development and management of geographical names;
- iv. Develop funding strategies to enable UNGEGN to assist Member States in achieving national geographical names objectives.

Alignment of Strategies to the UN Sustainable Development Goals

UNGEGN recognizes the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are the blueprint to achieve a better and more sustainable world. They address global challenges, including those related to poverty, inequality, climate, environmental degradation, prosperity and justice.

The monitoring of SDGs should be adequately supported by thematic analyses based on a set of geospatial data, of which are a core element. Therefore, optimizing the use of nationally authorized geographical names should be a prerequisite, expertise will be advantageous. This use of nationally standardized geographical names applies to all seventeen SDGs.

UNGEGN, through cultural, heritage and language recognition will help meet the “Transformation: leave no one behind” the poorest and most vulnerable, and countries in need of special attention. Particularly, UNGEGN will contribute to achieve “Strengthen efforts to protect and safeguard the world’s cultural and natural heritage.”

Promoting UNGEGN principles for standardizing geographical names by means of assistance, capacity building, inclusive UNGEGN meetings and democratic dissemination of UNGEGN principles and issues is an underlying factor for success in

- Promoting sustained, inclusive and sustainable economic growth

- Establishing resilient infrastructure

- Reducing inequality within and among countries

- Making cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable

- Promoting peaceful and inclusive societies for sustainable development, and

- Building effective, accountable and inclusive institutions at all levels

Dissemination of UNGEGN principles and standards for geographical names helps strengthen the means of implementation and global partnership for sustainable development.

Connections with other relevant UN bodies will be pursued to ensure that UNGEGN is managing its contribution to achieving the SDGs.

PROGRAMME OF WORK

Strategy 1: Technical Expertise

- i. Deliver technical expertise and advice to interested parties in Member States for geographical names standardization, including romanization, quality geographical names data and gazetteer management as well as interoperability;
- ii. Develop, extend and share good practices of Member States; and
- iii. Identify trends on developments and future direction for geographical names data management and encourage the use of innovative methods, integrated approaches and technological advances to further the aims of UNGEGN.

Current status and assessment

UNGEGN has promoted and provided policy, consultancy and technical advice to national standardization programmes on geographical names collection, management and dissemination, to training courses as well as on innovation and research activities. This has comprised the support of multipurpose database solutions as an essential part of spatial data infrastructures for national, regional and global use in the context of a broader geospatial information management:

Workshops and Training Courses

Training Courses on Toponymy have been supported with contributions to technical issues like data modelling, interoperability, database applications etc. conveying the message of standardized geographical names data being essential within a national geospatial information management

Workshops have been organized in conjunction with UNGEGN Sessions focusing on topics like data collection, categorization and modelling, interoperability, database applications or lessons learned through national and international geographical names programmes or projects

Presentations have been given on geographical names data management topics at international events

Databases and applications

Advice has been provided to the improvement of the Geographical Names Database of UNGEGN (UNGEGN database)

The "UNECA Africa GeoNyms database/gazetteer initiative" has been promoted, complemented and supported, mainly within Training Courses on Toponymy

The establishment of regional databases//gazetteers of geographical names (like in Europe or in Asia and Pacific) has been promoted

Data integration methods

Policy, consultancy and technical advice have been provided to the UN-GGIM activities related to the fundamental data theme 'Geographical Names'

Advice has been provided for the integration of geographical names data into the monitoring of sustainable development goals (SDGs) according to the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development

The use of persistent unique identifiers has been promoted as a crucial element of consistent geographical names within a wider geospatial information management

The use of romanization systems within the UUN has been achieved to enable systematic transfer between non-Roman and Romanized-script languages; comprising information sharing on other systems for writing systems without a UN-approved system

The use of Unicode consortium encodings has been supported for a correct data transfer of all characters and diacritics (including those beyond the 26 basic letters of a Roman alphabet)

Some further needs: The cooperation with and the contribution to activities of other UN bodies and Member States on cross-sectional tasks and issues like 'Sustainable Development Goal (SDG)

monitoring' or 'Linked (Open) Data' have to be strengthened and supported. Clarity and assistance on the implementation and use of UNN-agreed romanization systems have to be promoted further – both within the donor country and at the global implementation level. In general, geographical names data management has to be discussed in close relation with issues of romanization and of cultural heritage, language and minorities.

Action items, actors and time frame

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
1-i-1	Provide consultancy to the developmentss related to the UNGEGN database, UNECA "UNECA Africa a GeoNyms database/gazetteer r initiative", the INSPIRE initiative, the UN and European gazetteer projects, the GIS web-based World Geonames Application and other projects of developing countries	Bureau, WG GNDM, Task Team for Africa	Report on progress for each UNGEGN session to 2029 (if appropriate to be included in the report of the WG GNDM) Contributions to Training Courses on Toponymy to be assessed annually
1-i-2	Evaluate and assess exchange standards for geographical names information and for web services (gazetteer, feature and mapping) for the provision of geographical names information (comprising the review of Part II of the UNGEGN Technical Reference Manual)	WG GNDM	Report on exchange standards in 2023
1-i-3	Present geographical names data management topics at national and international conferences organized in the fields of geospatial information management	WG GNDM	Assess annually
1-i-4	Promote, agree and disseminate romanization systems for national and global use	WG GNDM, WG GNCH, WG RS	Assess annually
1-i-5	Promote and support the establishment of an authoritative international database/gazetteer of geographical names to be disseminated to the public through UNGEGN	Bureau, WG GNDM, WG GNCH WG RSs	Report on opportunities for an international database/gazetteer activity in 2023

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
1-ii-6	Examine processes and recommend good practice a. on how single and multi-jurisdictional Member States record, store, disseminate and manage their geographical names b. for the reuse and validation of volunteered geographic information, crowd sourced data and Linked Open Data (LOD) as part of national geographical names standardization work c. for the use of standardized geographical names as fundamental data theme in national spatial data infrastructures (SDIs) within the monitoring of the SDG indicator framework in order to analyze and monitor the changes in a country	WG GNDM, WG GNCH, WG RS	Report on good practices for each UNGEGN session to 2029
1-ii-7	Promote the use of the online discussion forum (Wiki) e.g. a. on the relationship UNGEGN – UN-GGIM or SDG indicator monitoring b. on data modelling and database design c. on general issues in the context of data maintenance (like feature classifications) d. on geographical names data production and distribution in the context of national, regional or global Spatial Data Infrastructures (SDIs)	WG GNDM	Assess annually
1-iii-8	Monitor the availability of free and easily-accessible authorized digital geographical names data as it is seen as a key driver in encouraging the use of nationally-standardized geographical names	WG GNDM	Assess annually
1-iii-9	Organize workshops and on innovative, research and/or technical issues/topics like e.g. volunteered geographic information, crowd sourced data, Linked Open Data or speech technology	WG GNDM, WG GNCH	Workshops in 2022-2025 (likely in conjunction with Division meetings)

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
1-iii-10	Evaluate and assess innovative methods to be used for Romanization, e.g. machine transliteration	WG RS	Report on innovative methods for Romanization for each UNGEGN session to 2029

Strategy 2: Relationships, links and connections

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Current status and assessment

UNGEGN has initiated and maintained to varying degrees, links with UN departments and agencies and non-UN scientific/technical organizations and groups, with either formal or informal liaison structures. Liaison with many groups has been active and effective, leading to provision of advice on the appropriate use of geographical names.

UN departments/agencies

ECOSOC: UNGEGN has reported through the UNCISGs or directly following sessions

UNESCO and UNPFII: special presentations at UNCISGs; individual Member States considered geographical names for recognition as intangible cultural heritage

UNECA: cooperation to further standardization of geographical names in countries of Africa; Task Team for Africa participated at meetings in Addis Ababa; UNECA organized a geographical names forum in Botswana and created Africa Geonyms - free database/gazetteer software for Member States' use

UN-GGIM: established cooperation to address Agenda 2030 and SDGs, including provision of advice on fundamental data theme of "Geographical Names" and ongoing contribution as members of the UN-GGIM Working Group on Fundamental Geospatial Data Themes

UN Documentation Division: recent liaison to advise on geographical names use within the UN; past interaction with terminology staff regarding country names data in UNTERM

WHO, UNGIS, OCHA, HABITAT, UNEP, UN Map Library: informal links and individuals have participated in UNGEGN sessions.

Non-UN commissions and organizations

Participation and leadership of UNGEGN experts in academic conferences of scientific bodies, so promoting the work of UNGEGN

ICA: long-established liaison; achievements such as on-line Toponymy Training Course

ICOS: a strong link, particularly for academic UNGEGN experts; UNGEGN experts have contributed to and edited issues of "Onoma", presented at Congresses, and the terminology groups of the organizations have cooperated for common good.

IGU: collaborated to establish ICA/IGU Commission on Toponymy

Monitoring of and contribution to international standards pertinent to geographical names and associated databases

ICANN: provided advice on proposed domain name submissions

IHO: formal liaison, with particular cooperation on undersea and maritime feature names, for example SCUFN and its documentation

Unicode Consortium and OGC: formal liaison arranged for encoding and exchange standards

ISO: UNGEGN has Class A Liaison status with TC211 (Geographic Information/Geomatics); an UNGEGN expert currently chairs TC46/WG3 (Conversion of Written Languages); UNGEGN experts are also participating in the work of other ISO groups (e.g. TC46/WG2 - Coding of Country Names and related entities)

SCAR: liaison for data in the Composite Gazetteer of Antarctica; advised on naming principles

Links to groups providing toponymic training in keeping with UNGEGN's needs

PAIGH: liaison with regard to toponymy training courses (Central & South America; in Spanish) and ICUTE (association of universities) that has established toponymic training

Initiation of other links

Google Earth: representatives have regularly attended UNGEGN sessions and made special presentations; individual Member States have as a result established contacts to ameliorate their national geographical names data used by Google

ICIPN: liaison with the Council was established in 2010, but only informal in nature

IMO, World Bank, ESRI, FIG: informal links; individuals have participated at UNGEGN sessions

Some further needs: Some links should be strengthened, a wider liaison network needs establishing and more “persuasion” is likely required for user groups to access and use nationally standardized geographical names. Greater cooperation is now required within the UN framework, creating a stronger link with ECOSOC and fostering cooperation with UNECA to further the standardization of geographical names in Africa.

Action items, actors and time frame

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
2-i-1	UNGEGN Bureau to contribute to ECOSOC requirements and to assess annually contributions to the UN-HLPF and the themes determined by ECOSOC for annual focus, and Agenda 2030	Chair, Bureau	Assess requirements annually
2-i-2	Interaction with UUN-GGIM to be continuously reviewed and evaluated for upgrading the activity level in relation to over-arching activities, such as addressing the SDGs	Chair, Bureau, WG GNDM	Assess relevant activities annually
2-i-3	Work with UNECA to establish stronger and more permanent ties aimed to: a. Increase national geographical names standardization in Africa b. Re-activate the Gaborone Action Plan (GAP) initiated with UNECA c. Re-activate Africa GeoNyms project to provide free database/gazetteer software to countries in Africa	a. Task Team for Africa, UNGEGN Divisions in Africa b. Task Team for Africa, UNGEGN Divisions in Africa c. Task Team for Africa, UNGEGN Divisions in Africa, WG GNDM	- a, b and c: - Re-establish ties in 2021 - Develop workable programmes and establish goals by 2023 - Report progress for each UNGEGN session to 2029
2-i-4	Further explore links with UNESCO to find a path to recognition of geographical names as a part of intangible cultural heritage of Member States	Bureau, WG GNCH, Member States	Develop practical links with UNESCO by 2025
2-i-5	Build on existing initiatives and cooperation to enhance the use of nationally-standardized geographical names and to provide advice to the UN Documentation Division and SALB	WG RS, WG CN, Member States	Establish ongoing liaison with UN Documentation Division and with SALB in 2021

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
2-ii-6	Continue to communicate and liaise with existing groups and explore further effective ways of cooperation with: ICA, I COS, IGU, IHO, IISO, OGC, PAIGH, SCAR, Unicode Consortium	Existing liaison arrangements, individual Member States, individual experts	Explore more formal arrangement with IGU (as requested) by 2023
2-iii-7	Initiate appropriate links with UNPFII, ICIPN and other indigenous groups to enhance UNGEGN's understanding of the significance of geographical names to indigenous peoples and the retention of their languages	WG GNCH, individual Member States	Initiate links and establish suitable ongoing communication with UNPFII by 2023
2-iii-8	Look at building a strong tie with ICUTE and providing input into their programming as it relates to, and supports, the needs of UNGEGN training	WG TC	Establish productive liaison with ICUTE by 2023 and determine opportunities for UNGEGN to participate in ICUTE training (and vice-versa)
2-iii-9	Establish cooperation with sub-groups/initiatives off UN-GGIM (e.g. CARIGEO) to help create or enhance national standardization of geographical names worldwide	WG P&F; WG TC	Determine UN-GGIM sub-groups/initiatives that are related to geographical names by 2023 (ongoing)
2-iii-10	To enhance the understanding of the aims and work of UNGEGN, to provide advice on geographical names use or on accessibility of data and contacts, there should be an effort to reach out to a wider world of potential geographical names users and to encourage their participation at UNGEGN Sessions. This would include UN and non-UN bodies that may be unfamiliar with UNGEGN's purpose	Appoint an individual point person or WG P&F	

Strategy 3: Effective work programmes

- i. Encourage active participation and promote compatible standards and methods in the work undertaken by Member States to contribute to UNGEGN's aims;
- ii. Deliver products, outcomes, policy guidance and advice that support coordinated activities at national, divisional and international levels, taking note of UNGEGN resolutions and recommendations and leveraging social media, mobile applications and web-based tools;
- iii. Ensure that UNGEGN's organizational structure is appropriate, efficient, relevant and impactful to deliver maximum value to Member States; and
- iv. Encourage exchange of knowledge, good practices and experience among Member States, aided by Divisions and Working Groups, to facilitate development of legislation and policies on geographical names standardization at the national level.

Current status and assessment

UNGEEN has sought efficient ways to share commonly agreed principles on geographical names standardization and good practices of Member States through a series of discussions, resolutions, recommendations, products and outcomes. Its organizational structure including Working Groups and Divisions has been established to support effective operation of its work programmes.

Participation, products, outcomes, policy guidance and advice

An increasing number of Member States have participated in the former Conferences and sessions so far, established common principles of the standardization of geographical names, shared their experiences, and benefited from good practices of others. However, there are still Member States which have not yet participated and/or have problems in participating due to lack of awareness, funding, etc.

Products of more than fifty-years of geographical names standardization have been published or compiled and are available from the UNGEEN website, including reports of meetings, individual working papers, special presentation materials, three manuals (basic, technical and training), a glossary of terms (with a searchable database), a list of country names, the World Geographical Names database and Toponymic Guidelines for Map and Other Editors of more than 40 Member States (links provided). Publications need to be reviewed for possible updating to accommodate current trends of geographical names standardization. Toponymic Guidelines are expected to be available from an extended number of Member States.

Resolutions adopted at the eleven former Conferences provide good guidance for the national standardization of geographical names in each Member State. They have been compiled in a compendium and in a searchable online database in six and five languages, respectively. However, there should be more awareness of the resolutions as a reference for the national standardization of geographical names.

A growing number of Member States have established geographical names authorities to facilitate organized management of geographical names, which is expected to be extended to more Member States.

Modalities and organizational structure

Following the decision of ECOSOC in 2017 to create a combined body of the former UNCSGN and UNGEEN with the name UNGEEN, its first biennial session was convened in 2019 over a period of five days. The new UNGEEN is searching for a more organized operation as an inter-governmental body representing Member States of which experts play a crucial role.

Each of the Working Groups (currently 9 in operation, 33 disbanded), one Task Team and one Coordinator has been carrying out or completed its specific goals as commissioned by UNGEEN. Twenty-four geographical/linguistic Divisions have functioned as groups of Member States to support regional or language-based grass-roots interaction on geographical names standardization. The linkage and cooperation between Working Groups and Divisions need to be enhanced to secure expertise or synergy effects. The function and operation of Divisions need to be reviewed and, if required, adjusted in the new modalities of UNGEEN.

Some further needs: More precise monitoring and evaluating UNGEEN's work programme is needed in order to increase its efficiency. More elaborated relevance of UNGEEN to achieve the 2030 SDGs should be addressed in its work programmes. Ongoing encouragement and enabling is needed for all Member States to have national geographical names standardization policies and legislation.

Action items, actors and time frame

No.	Action Items	Actors/ Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
3-i-1	Encourage Member States to participate in UNGEGN sessions and activities; SSecure funds to support participation off those who need assistance (<i>see also Strategy 5</i>)	Bureau, WG P&F, Secretariat	Assess annually
3-ii-2	Review the current versions of UNGEGN publications, establish a plan to revise or add to them, and implement it	Bureau, WG P&F, WG RS, WG GNDM, WG TT, WG CN	Review and plan in 2021; if needed, draft, edit and publish by 2023
3-ii-3	Take measures to encourage and promote the publication and revision of the Toponymic Guidelines	Coordinator TG, WG TC	Assess annually. Take note in training courses
3-ii-4	Codify the resolutions and recommendations into a coherent and hierarchical whole	Bureau, WG E&I	Review and plan in 2021; prior work done by 2023; subsequent work after 2023, if needed
3-ii-5	Encourage experts to refer to the resolutions and recommendations in their work and particularly in preparing working papers	Bureau, WG E&I, Secretariat	Report to every session; announce in the documentation
3-ii-6	Continue to maintain and update the compendium and database of the resolutions and recommendations	WG E&I, Secretariat	Redesign the compendium and database in 2021; update following every session
3-iii-7	Review the function and operation of Divisions and consider any change in the organizational structure of UNGEGN	Bureau, WG E&I, Division chairs	Initiate in 2021; rounds of discussions and feedbacks by 2023; and then an adjustment made by 2025, if needed.
3-iii-8	Review the documentation guidelines and submission schedule for national/divisional reports and, if needed, elaborate them	Bureau, WG E&I, Secretariat	Assess for every session
3-iii-9	Encourage WG convenors and Division chairs to share and develop ideas of linking and cooperating with each other	Bureau, all WGs, Division chairs	Ongoing up to 2029
3-iii-10	Monitor and evaluate UNGEGN's work programme regularly	Bureau, WG E&I, WG P&F	Assess annually; organize Bureau and WG meetings in 2022, 2024, 2026

No.	Action Items	Actors/ Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
3-iii-11	Elaborate relevant aspects of UNGEGN to the goals and targets of sustainable development and find ways to develop them in its work programmes	Bureau, all WGs	Assess annually; plan a report on implementing SDGs in UNGEGN by 2023, progress reports in 2025, 2027, 2029
3-iv-12	Elaborate measures to increase the number of Member States that have functioning authorities for geographical names standardization	Bureau, WG E&I, WG TC, WG GNCH	Ongoing; encourage organizing discussion forums

Strategy 4: Culture, heritage and language recognition

i.	Declare, promote, celebrate and demonstrate that geographical names matter because they recognize unique culture, heritage and language that connect people to physical locations;
ii.	Promote good geographical naming practices that acknowledge people's place in the world;
iii.	Recognize that geographical names are a source of identity, encourage recognition of heritage and equality, and support indigenous, regional and/or minority groups' language revitalization and preservation; and
iv.	Contribute to building technical capabilities, such as developing guidelines, legislation, communication tools and databases to enhance culture, heritage and language recognition.

Current status and assessment

UNGEGN has encouraged the development of principles and practices to support the less tangible social concepts of geographical naming. These include connection to place through traditional, ancestral, historical, cultural, and language associations. Recognizing the importance of these human needs acknowledges a sense of place and why geographical names matter. Beyond the practical need for communicating location identification, geographical names preserve identity and belonging.

Recommendations, initiatives, programmes and training

As more emphasis was given to geographical names as cultural heritage, a number of UNCSD Conference resolutions on this subject were passed, for example, VIII/9, IX/4 and X/3. Several resolutions have promoted collection and recognition of indigenous and minority toponyms (for example, II/26, V/22, VIII/1, IX/5, VII/9, IX/10); and UNGEGN Recommendation 5 (2019), follows up I/16 and I/20 in addressing geographical names from unwritten languages.

Following the 8th Conference in 2002 a Working Group was established to promote the recording and use of Indigenous, Minority Group and Regional Language geographical names; in 2012 it took on a simpler name with the wider scope of "cultural heritage".

"Geographical names and cultural heritage" is a regular Agenda topic at UNGEGN sessions and was the theme of the *UNGEGN Information Bulletin*, No. 48, May 2015.

Symposia organized by UNGEGN, Divisions or Working Groups have included : "Toponyms in multilingual areas", Netherlands (2005); and geographical names as cultural heritage, Vienna (2008), Seoul (2014), Florence (2015). A workshop on implementing resolutions on commemorative names was held during the 29th UNGEGN session in Bangkok (2016).

Special presentations on intangible cultural heritage have been made by UNESCO at Conferences in 2007 and 2012 and some Member States have worked towards possible UNESCO recognition of particular groups of geographical names.

At both Conferences and Sessions individual Member States have presented documents reflecting their progress in various areas of cultural heritage, identity, multilingualism, indigenous naming, etc. and these are available on the UNGEGN website.

UNGEGN has reached out to indigenous organizations, such as UNPFII and ICIPN to participate at UNGEGN sessions.

The UNGEGN toponymy training manual, the on-site and online training courses, the basic manual and the Media kit include sections and presentations on geographical names as cultural heritage.

Achievements

From its initial technical roots, UNGEGN has over the years increasingly placed significance on the cultural value of geographical names, and this topic has been included in UNGEGN's toponymic training programmes.

Many UNGEGN participant countries have made and continue to make remarkable progress on their domestic work on declaring, promoting and celebrating the unique connections between culture, heritage, language and geographical names.

UNGEGN has recognized the requirement for support to, for example, unwritten languages, which are necessarily from regional and/or minority language communities.

UNGEGN has also recognized the need to understand exonym use and the Working Group on Exonyms is active in examining this topic. There are many available publications including an ongoing book series, Name & Place, comprising the Working Group's papers.

Participation and leadership of UNGEGN experts in academic conferences of scientific bodies considering cultural heritage, e.g. International Congress of Onomastic Sciences, so promoting the work of UNGEGN.

There has been some provision of advice to organizations (UN and non-UN) on the benefits of recognizing the intangible cultural heritage through geographical names.

Some further needs: Some Member States have significant work to do in declaring, promoting, celebrating and recognizing the importance of the unique connections between culture, heritage, language and geographical names. Relationships with external bodies could be further developed to strengthen and enhance the connection that geographical names have with culture and heritage, e.g. UNESCO, UNPFII. UNGEGN could facilitate member states' progress in this field by sharing 'model' or 'example' case studies from other members, on particular issues. Greater support could be offered to develop writing systems for unwritten languages, thereby providing a means of representing geographical names in a standard way and allowing these to receive a wider audience. A financial impact may be relevant as the benefits of recognizing culture and heritage do not necessarily have an obvious tangible advantage, and therefore may be overlooked or side-lined by some Member States.

Action items, actors and time frame

As the scope of cultural heritage is wide there will be several formalized, structured and active Focus Groups within the WG on Geographical Names as Cultural Heritage:

1. Geographical names in relation to minorities and indigenous people
2. Legislation, policies & best practices relating to geographical names
3. Commercial and commemorative naming, including urban naming
4. Crowd sourcing for collecting stories behind the names
5. The names of unwritten languages
6. Naming within tourism and branding

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
4-i-1	Liaise with UNPFII and its members to better appreciate geographical names as part of indigenous cultural heritage and language retention	Bureau, WG GNCH, Member States	Liaison with UNPFII: initiated by 2023 and continuing
4-i-2	Provide supportive evidence (e.g. pamphlet) as to the significance of geographical names on culture, identity and language	WG GNCH (Focus Group 2), WG P&F	Pamphlet or other: concept and draft text by 2023; document ((likely in English) for 2025; other languages 2025-2029
4-i-3	Investigate the need for cooperation to advise on and share experiences on methods for crowd sourcing relating to urban naming and street naming processes, and the relationship with relevant SDGs (e.g. sustainable cities)	Bureau, WG GNCH (Focus Groups 3 & 4)	Urban naming: plan for 2023 and ongoing implementation Crowd sourcing: 2025 and beyond – encourage papers/discussion at UNGEGN sessions
4-i-4	Share experience on cooperation with emergency services, tourism operators, brand consultants and other providers of services useful to society, e.g. plurilingual societies	WG GNCH (Focus Groups 1 & 6)	Emergency services, tourism operators, brand consultants: initial examples for 2023; wider scope for 2025 and beyond
4.ii-5	Share Member States treatment of geographical names in indigenous, minority and regional language groups (policies and principles, field collection methodology, naming of both cultural and physical features, etc.)	WG GNCH (Focus Group 1), Member States	Indigenous, minority and regional language group naming: ongoing, with specified goals and milestones proposed by 2023

No.	Action Items	Actors/Responsibility	Output and Time Frame
4-ii-6	Share effective practices and applications of culturally-oriented resolutions, such as commemorative naming and commercialization of naming	WG E&I, WG GNCH (Focus Group 2)	Re resolutions: plan of selected topics for 2023; discussion groups as side events during UNGEGN sessions
4-ii-7	Encourage presentations and discussions relevant to current key cultural aspects of naming and renaming, and to naming in particular environments	WG GNCH, Member States	Naming and renaming: encourage papers/discussion at each UNGEGN session Physical environments: encourage papers/discussion at UNGEGN sessions
4-ii-8	Investigate recognition of geographical names by UNESCO as part of intangible cultural heritage	Bureau, WG GNCH, Member States	UNESCO: report of findings by 2025
4-ii-9	Cooperate with academia, so that geographical name datasets collected (by academics, for example, historical or linguistic variants) are geo-referenced and linked to standardized datasets	WG GNCH, WG GNDM	Academic datasets: 2025 and ongoing
4-iii-10	The Working Group on Exonyms to continue the examination of and publications on, the treatment, use and reduction of exonyms in the context of geographical names standardization and effective UN communication.	WG E	Exonyms: ongoing reporting
4-iv-11	Contribute to the rationale for creation of national authorities with legal rights/obligations to standardize geographical names	WG GNCH (Focus Group 2), WG P&F	Creation of national authorities: ongoing, with specified goals and milestones proposed by 2023
4-iv-12	Investigate principles and methodology for recording and writing geographical names from unwritten languages	WG GNCH (Focus Group 5), WG RS	Unwritten languages: outline of challenges, benefits and possible goals for 2023; sample study for 2025; wider application for 2029

Strategy 5: Promotion and capacity building

- i. Raise awareness of the importance of using standardized geographical names and their role as a crucial element of geospatial information;
- ii. Enhance the visibility of UNGEGN through its publications, improved communications, outreach, networking and partnerships;
- iii. Assist Member States in their capacity building and in the development and management of geographical names standardization; and
- iv. Develop funding strategies to enable UNGEGN to assist Member States in achieving national geographical names standardization.

Current status

Up-to-date UNGEGN website, established in 2002, has been maintained and been through several re-iterations to address design and content, including: 1) The UNGEGN World Geographical Names Database (2004), 2) A searchable database of all resolutions and downloadable documents in four UN languages and two non-UN languages, 3) Information on UNGEGN's Divisions, Working Groups and Task Teams, 4) Reports from all the meetings under the auspices of UNGEGN, including working papers, conference room papers, special presentations and additional documents, 5) Publicity material, including manuals related to geographical names, brochures and media kit to publicize the work and goals of UNGEGN, 6) Information on toponymic laws and regulations regarding Member States.

Biannual UNGEGN Bulletin issues, since 2013 with thematic issues. Established as the de-facto media to report on developments and upcoming events in matters related to UNGEGN or within the scope of geographical names.

Wikipedia presence in multiple languages.

Twitter presence.

Enabling participation at UNGEGN events for members from developing countries through funding from a variety of sources to enable the participation in Conferences/Sessions.

Funds from UN Statistics have supported training courses in various parts of the world.

Press releases written and processed before and after Conferences and Sessions.

Presentations made by UNGEGN experts at academic and scientific conferences promoting the work of UNGEGN.

UNEGN has assisted in capacity building by providing on-site training since 1982, essentially in response to Divisional needs, and has produced training modules available free through the website to all interested individuals in association with ICA.

Further work to be done: Generally, the work of UNGEGN and importance of geographical names standardization is still poorly understood and appreciated in many Member States and outside organizations.

Direct UNGEGN web presence maintains a good standard, although a number of sub-pages are in need of improvement.

UNEGN World Geographical Names Database page has not been updated with the recent upgrade. In need of reinvention.

Member States contributions to web presence must be developed to ensure up-to-date information. Without requests/persuasion few UNGEGN experts provide updated information, such as national names authority data, contact information, city names for the UNGEGN database, etc.

Although many UNGEGN publications continue to be relevant 10-20 years later, content needs to be reviewed for updating.

Better arrangements need to be in place for the UNGEGN Secretariat to be able to update and provide visual and map representation, such information as Member States with national names authorities, Member States with toponymic guidelines, which Member States have supplied data to the UNGEGN database, where training courses have been held, etc.

Bulletin standard is high with relevant topics for information, capacity building, and toponymic issues. However, editorial proof-reading capacity in all UNGEGN languages must be ensured. To ensure relevance and actuality, a list of topics must be maintained and regularly updated. The development of templates for contribution could be beneficial.

Wiki-presence is good, regularly updated, although a more active editorial presence is necessary, as the current situation is under-robust.

Social-media presence adequate, although a more active editorial presence is necessary, as the current situation is under-robust. There is also room to improve on social media communication in intervals between meetings.

Mechanisms for providing funding for participants from developing countries in place. However, the funding situation is not robust therefore, an UNGEGN trust fund needs to be established.

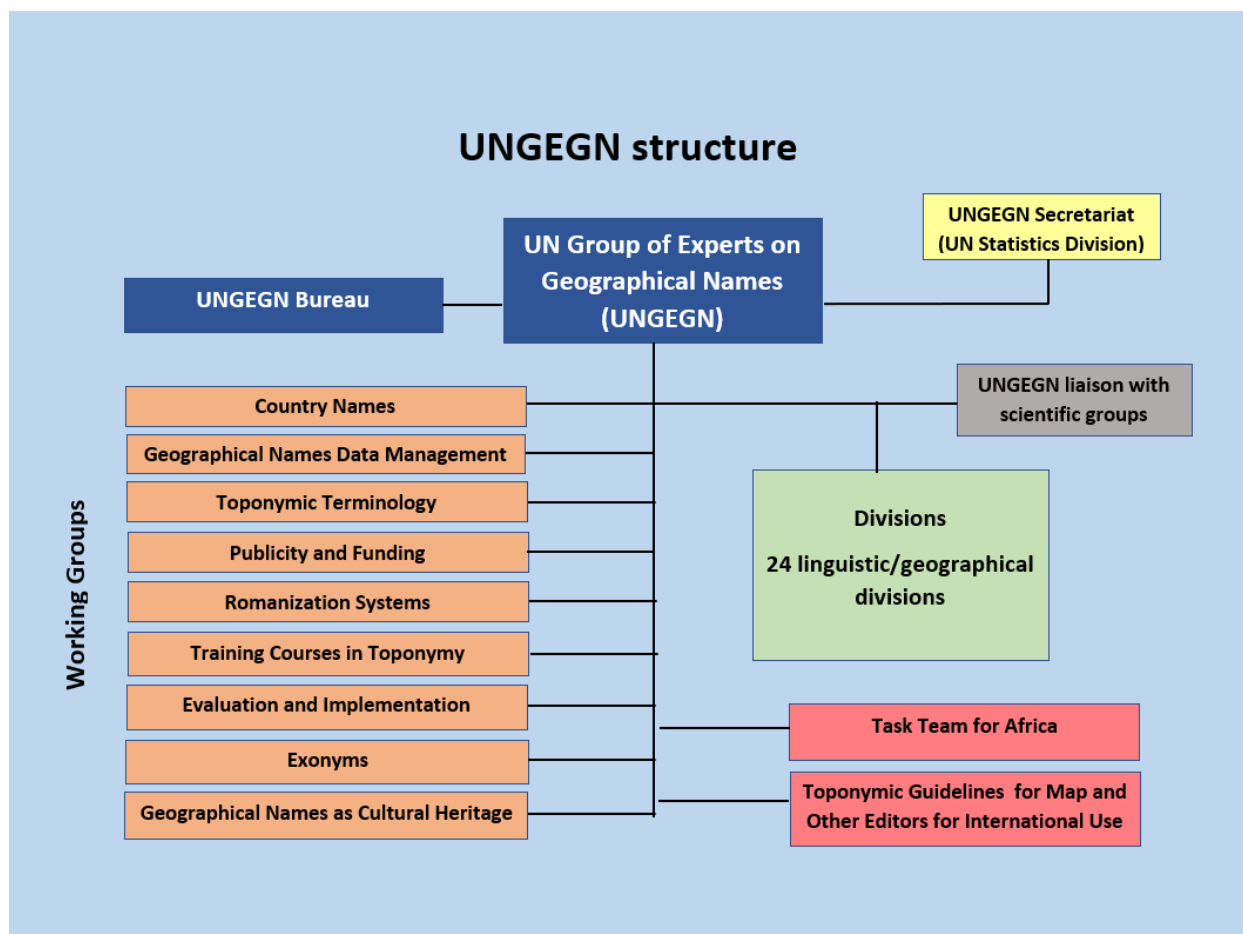
Action items, actors and time frame

No.	Action items	Actors/responsibility	Output and Time Frame
5.i.1	Develop plans for awareness raising and increase promotion of UNGEGN geographical names standardization	Task Team for Africa (WG A) UNGEGN Chair WG P&F	1. Implement model for regular production and circulation of information sheet pertinent to standardization issues in Africa ((2021). 2. Implement cooperation with UN-GGIM and its sub-units to promote the value of standardized geographical names and processes involved to achieve this (2022). 3. Implement procedures for ensuring strong involvement of users of geographical names as speakers and observers at UNGEGN sessions (2023).
5.i.2	Monitor and evaluate promotion and capacity building	WG P&F	1. Ensure relevant and updated capacity building material is available at UNGEGN website (2022). 2. Implement review procedure for updating capacity-building material (2023).
5.ii.3	UNGEGN Website development and maintenance	WG P&F	1. Re-develop UNGEGN World Geographical Names webpage (end of 2021) 2. Develop plan for stricter monitoring of UNGEGN website with higher member nation involvement to ensure content maintains up-to-date, including review procedures for updating and creation of content and better visual representation of achievements ((e.g. Member states with names authorities, toponymic guidelines, etc.). 3. Update UNGEGN website content and link the UNGEGN webpage with the related toponymic webpages from the Member States (2022) 4. Implement system for ensuring up-to-date information on UNGEGN website (2022) Implement website modernizations at 6 years intervals (2025)

No.	Action items	Actors/responsibility	Output and Time Frame
5.ii.4	Ensuring relevance, development and dissemination of UNGEGN Bulletin	WG P&F	1. Implement yearly evaluations of future topics and ensure focus on the topics investigated in issues (2021) - Expand distribution of UNGEGN Bulletin ((2021-2029)
5.iii.5	Ensuring international Toponymy Training Courses for the future.	WG TC	1. Establish and maintain a complete group of trainers for international Toponymy Training Courses (2021). 2. Ensure as complete competences as possible in Toponymy Training (2022). 3. Implement procedures for regular review, update and content creation relating to toponymic training materials (2024). - Implement online courses and workshops on specific topics for training relevant to national geographical names standardization ((2024).
5.iii.6	Establish social-media group to increase level of activity on Twitter.	WG P&F	1. Implement robust model for and organization of social media presence (2023)
5.iv.7	Explore possibility of UNGEGN trust fund for capacity building and enabling participation	WG P&F	1. Identify areas of UNGEGN in need of funding (2021) 2. Establish legal framework of UNGEGN trust fund, purpose and range of activities (2023). 3. Begin attracting funding to UNGEGN trust fund, if previous point suggests viability (2024) 4. Launch UNGEGN Trust Fund (2027, or earlier)

IMPLEMENTATION FRAMEWORK

Organization Chart



Membership, Bureau, Working Groups, Task Teams, Divisions

The Group of Experts is composed of representatives of States Members of the United Nations, including experts appointed by Governments. In appointing their representatives, member States

designate experts with specific knowledge drawn from the interrelated fields of geography, cartography, geospatial information, linguistics and history.

Divisions of the Group of Experts comprise the major linguistic and geographical divisions of the world, as listed in the Appendix. Member States decide for themselves the division(s) to which they wish to belong; some belong to more than one division. Each division is expected to stimulate activities in the standardization of geographical names within the division, through technical meetings, exchange of experiences, correspondence, etc. Currently, there are 24 Divisions that guide the work of UNGEGN during and between its sessions.

Working Groups are created to follow up topics and issues which cut across the divisional structure of UNGEGN. Currently, nine Working Groups are in operation. In addition, UNGEGN has a Task Team for Africa and a Coordinator for the Toponymic Guidelines. The current work plans of these Working Groups, Task Team and Coordinator are listed in the Strategic Plan. A working group is disbanded when it has fulfilled its mandate.

The Bureau is composed of one chair, two vice-chairs and two rapporteurs. The Bureau, Working Group convenors, coordinators and former chairs meet regularly through teleconferencing or face-to-face meetings.

Secretariat support to UNGEGN is provided by the UN Statistics Division.

Monitoring, Reporting and Evaluation

The UNGEGN Strategic Plan and Programme of Work 2021-2029 provides a general framework of UNGEGN's activities to support the standardization of geographical names in each Member State. In order to achieve the vision and aims, the UNGEGN Bureau, Working Groups and Divisions will deliver and pursue the respective action plans as specified in each strategy. UNGEGN sessions held biennially will be an effective forum to report on the progress of the activities that each component of UNGEGN has achieved during the intersessional period, and to evaluate and make updates and amendments to the Plan, as appropriate. The UNGEGN structure including the Working Groups and Divisions will be assessed based on the efficiency of implementing action plans and, if needed, proposed to be reorganized. Each Member State is invited to report on its activities to implement the Plan in the UNGEGN sessions.

Financing

An important element in achieving the goals set out here lies in developing funding strategies to enable UNGEGN to assist Member States in achieving national geographical names standardization. A funding strategy is outlined under item 5.iv. Explore possibility of UNGEGN trust fund for capacity building and enabling participation. The outline sets the course for an establishment of a legal framework of an UNGEGN Trust Fund becoming a part of the umbrella UN Trust Fund, a time frame for funding attraction, and eventual launch.

Key to this work is the implementation of a Terms of Reference to provide a mandate for the establishment and purpose of the trust fund, including possible sources of funding, and which UNGEGN activities are to be supported from the fund. Approval of the UNGEGN strategic plan and programme of work 2021-2029 should secure the necessary mandate for creating an UNGEGN Trust Fund and paves the way forward to identifying donors in order to secure the necessary funds for a sustainable UNGEGN of the future.

APPENDIX

Linguistic or geographical divisions of the United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names

1. Africa Central Division
2. Africa East Division
3. Africa South Division
4. Africa West Division
5. Arabic Division
6. Asia East Division (other than China)
7. Asia South-East Division
8. Asia South-West Division (other than Arabic)
9. Baltic Division
10. Celtic Division
11. China Division
12. Dutch- and German-speaking Division
13. East Central and South-East Europe Division
14. Eastern Europe, Northern and Central Asia Division
15. East Mediterranean Division (other than Arabic)
16. French-speaking Division
17. India Division
18. Latin America Division
19. Norden Division
20. Pacific South-West Division
21. Portuguese-speaking Division
22. Romano-Hellenic Division
23. United Kingdom Division
24. United States of America/Canada Division

ABBREVIATIONS

UNGEGN and its Working Groups

Abbreviation	Full name and URL
UNCSGN	<i>United Nations Conference on the Standardization of Geographical Names</i>

UNGEGN	United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/
WG CN	Working Group on Country Names https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg1.cshtml
WG E	Working Group on Exonyms https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg8.cshtml http://uneggn.zrc-ssazu.si/Home.aspx
WG E&I	Working Group on Evaluation and Implementation https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg7.cshtml http://www.ngii.go.kr/pportal/ungn/mainEn.do (UNCSGN resolutions database)
WG GNCH	Working Group on Geographical Names as Cultural Heritage https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg9.cshtml
WG GNDM	Working Group on Geographical Names Data Management https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg2.cshtml https://wiki.gdi-de.org/display/wwgtdfg/Working+Group+on+Toponymic+Data+Files+and+Gazetteers+of+UNGEGN
WG P&F	Working Group on Publicity and Funding https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg4.cshtml
WG RS	Working Group on Romanization Systems https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg5.cshtml http://www.eki.ee/wwgrs/
WG TC	Working Group on Training Courses in Toponymy https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg6.cshtml https://unstats.un.org/unsd/geoinfo/UNGEGN/ddocs/_data_ICAcourses/index.html (webcourse on toponymy)
WG TT	Working Group on Toponymic Terminology https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wg3.cshtml http://ortsnamen.at/een/uneggn_glossary/ (toponymic terminology database)
TT Africa	Task Team for Africa https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wgAfrica.cshtml
Coordinator TG	Coordinator for the Toponymic Guidelines for Map and Other Editors for International Use https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/wworking_groups/wgGuidelines.cshtml https://unstats.un.org/unsd/uneggn/naa/toponymic/ (links to TGs of MSs)

United Nations and its bodies oother than UNGEGN

Abbreviation	Full name and URL
CARIGEO	Caribbean Geospatial Initiative of UN-GGIM A America http://www.un-ggim-americas.org/en/assets/mmodulos/proyectos.html?proyecto=5
ECOSOC	United Nations Economic a and Social Council https://www.un.org/eecosoc/
HLPF	United Nations High-llevel Political Forum on Sustainable D Development https://sustainabledevelopment.un.org/hlpf
OCHA	United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs https://www.unocha.org/aabout-ocha
SALB	Second Administrative L Level Boundaries https://www.unsalb.org/
UN	United Nations https://www.un.org/
UNECA	United Nations Economic C Commission for Africa https://www.uneca.org/
UNEP	United Nations Environment P Programme https://www.unep.org/
UNESCO	United Nations Educational Scientific and Cultural Organization https://en.unesco.org/
UN-GGIM	United Nations C Committee of Experts oon Global Geospatial Information anagement http://ggim.un.org/
UNPFII	United Nations Permanent Forum oon Indigenous Issues https://www.un.org/development/desa/indigenouspeoples/unpfii-sessions-2.html
WHO	World Health Organization https://www.who.int/

UN Geospatial (former C Cartography) <https://www.un.org/geospatial/>

UN-Habitat <https://unhabitat.org/>

UN Map Library <https://research.un.org/een/maps/>

International organizations, commissions and academic groups

Abbreviation	Full name and URL
AOCRS / AOCT	African Organization of Cartography and Remote Sensing / Organisation africaine de cartographie et de télédétection https://uia.org/s/oor/en/1100004655
FIG	International Federation of Surveyors https://www.fig.net/
GEBCO	General Bathymetric Chart of the Oceans https://www.gebco.net/
ICA	International Cartographic Association https://icaci.org/
ICANN	Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers https://www.icann.org/
ICIPN	International Council on Indigenous Place Names http://ourlanguages.org.au/eexploring-ways-to-reclaim-cultural-identity-through-place-names/ (Conference in 2010)
ICOS	International Council of Onomastic Sciences https://icosweb.net/
ICUTE	International Consortium of Universities for Toponymic Education
IGU	International Geographical Union https://igu-online.org/
IHO	International Hydrographic Organization https://iho.int/
IMO	International Maritime Organization https://www.imo.org/
INSPIRE	Infrastructure for Spatial Information in Europe https://inspire.ec.europa.eu/
ISO	International Organization for Standardization https://www.iso.org/
OGC	Open Geospatial Consortium https://www.ogc.org/

PAIGH	Pan American Institute of Geography and History https://ipgh.org/
RCMRD	Regional Centre for Mapping of Resources for Development (Nairobi) https://rcmrd.org/
SCAGI	Standing Committee on Antarctic Geographic Information https://www.scar.org/resources/sscagi/overview/
SCAR	Scientific Committee on Antarctic Research https://www.scar.org/
SCUFN	GEBCO Sub-Committee on Undersea Feature Names https://iho.int/en/scufn

Unicode consortium <https://home.unicode.org/>

Related terminologies

Abbreviation	Full name
GIS	geographic information system
SDI	spatial data infrastructure
SDGs	Sustainable Development Goals https://www.un.org/sustainabledevelopment/sustainable-development-goals/
UNTERM	United Nations Terminology Database (multilingual) https://unterm.un.org/unterm/portal/welcome